viewed as burdensome by Gandhi. Conversely, the Khalq was predominantly rural and heavily Pashtun in its demographic composition, making it susceptible to tribal politicking. Observers at the time believed that neither of the two factions were 'good communists', but dealing with an urban leader who commanded authority in Kabul was easier for Gandhi than dealing with the Khalqis.[120]

Still, Gandhi was in for a surprise on 19 July 1980, the inaugural day of the 1980 Summer Olympics being held in Moscow (boycotted by the West). In the wake of the Soviet Union's Olympics distraction, Afghan interior minister Gulabzoi and deputy PM Sarwari, allegedly, planned a coup against Karmal. In a top-secret operation, which, ironically was reported in the media, they planned to assassinate Karmal and pass it as a plane crash (similar to Zia's mysterious death in 1988) with help from Khalqi sympathisers at the Kabul airport and in the national Ariana Airlines.[121] Rifts within the PDPA were becoming acute. On 25 June 1980 Sarwari, allegedly wounded in a shooting inside the Ministry of Foreign Affairs building, had flown to Moscow ostensibly for medical treatment.[122] On his return, allegedly, the above-mentioned events unfolded. As a step towards executing the plan, the president of Ariana Airlines (a Parcham supporter) was put out of play (in order to reduce any chances of Karmal escaping Kabul?). A few days before the Olympic games, the man went missing. Well versed with the ways of the Kabul durbar, it did not take Karmal long to sense foul play. He ordered the arrest of twelve Kabul airport employees on 21 July 1980, marginalised Gulabzoi (but did not sack him given his weight within the PDPA), dispatched Sarwari to Mongolia as ambassador, and appointed his loyalist Sultan Ali Keshtmand as chairman of the Council of Ministers and Minister of Planning.[123]

Having vowed not to interfere in domestic Afghan politics and to accept whoever was de facto in power, Gandhi did not make a fuss about the issue. However, Indian ambassador Jaskaran Teja's days in Kabul became numbered. Though it remains unclear how exactly Teja handled this crisis, the MEA was not impressed by his performance. New Delhi had been getting conflicting information about events in Kabul from its embassy for the previous six months. Senior diplomats, including I. K. Gujral, who would later become PM, were